

[DC] The Adaptation of Caribbean Literary Texts into VR

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ABSTRACT

This position paper discusses my interdisciplinary research which combines narratological theories and the characteristics of VR as a storytelling medium to develop a methodology for the adaptation of Caribbean literary narratives into VR. The selected narratives treat with contemporary issues such as migration, racial- discrimination and its perpetuation from history to present, and prejudice towards LGBTQIA individuals. These thematic areas enable their VR adaptations to contribute to social transformation by positioning users within story situations using character-based avatars or voyeuristic perspectives. The intended result is to create cognitive dissonance within the mind of the user and potentially alter negative attitudes and evoke empathetic responses. This research attempts to catalyze the use of VR as a storytelling medium for educational and social transformation purposes within the Caribbean region.

Keywords: VR, Caribbean literature, narrative theory, storytelling, focalisation, ethics, media

Index Terms: [Virtual Reality Adaptations]: Storytelling and Computations; Caribbean Literature in VR [Storyworlds, Focalisation, Ethics]

1 INTRODUCTION

With the growing popularity of VR for storytelling within the field of journalism and for social awareness, I propose that VR can be used as a narrative modality for the conveyance of Caribbean fictional narratives. In her article, Koski states that “the same factors which lend VR its ‘wow’ factor are inherent in any narrative be it fiction or non [*sic*]” [1, p.10]. The determining factor in the selection of the narratives are their length and treatment with contemporary global socio-political and socio- cultural issues such as migration, racial discrimination, and LGBTQIA issues. At present there are several non-fictional VR narratives which discuss these issues such as the UK Guardian’s *Limbo*[2], George Zimmerman’s *One Dark Night*[3, p.209], which recounts the murder of Trayvon Martin, and *Another Dream* [4] which recounts the escape of an Egyptian lesbian couple amidst persecution. From these examples, it is evident that there are several existing narratives on these issues, but none of these issues are based on their existence within the Caribbean region or on regional events. My research attempts to fill this gap by creating virtual reality narratives which represent these issues as they exist within the region thereby eliminating the creation of a technological metanarrative which presents social issues as being identically manifested across all territories. The selected texts include Lawrence Scott’s *Aelred’s Sin*, Nalo Hopkinson’s *Midnight Robber*, Marlon James’ *The Book of Night Women*, and Nalo

Hopkinson’s “Shift” from the short-story collection, *Falling in Love with Hominids*.

By adapting these narratives into VR, users will be able to encounter these issues through new perspectives from which they may be geographically or psychologically removed. The intended purpose of these VR experiences is to raise social awareness and evoke empathetic responses to the narrative content. Conversely, I do acknowledge that negative psychological reactions can be evoked by the virtual environment and users may practice negative real-world behaviors within the virtual world. As such, my research is informed by the potential ethical implications involved in immersing users into narrative events which depict violence and sexual encounters. This is further supported by claim that VR experiences which convey morally, or ethically compromising events can have long-term effects on users [5, p.158-164].

2 AREAS OF INQUIRY

Storyworlding, focalization and ethics are the three areas analyzed throughout the PhD research. It combines narrative theory, literature, and collected primary and secondary data (discussed in 2.2) to create a methodology and provide recommendations. The storyworlds in the selected texts have been placed into two categories: (1) imagined storyworlds, and (2) storyworlds derived from real-world spaces. The investigation of imagined storyworlds examines the elements of Caribbean culture and history which are used to foreground the thematic concerns in section 1. In many instances throughout the narratives, these historical and cultural elements are tangibly represented and should be included within the virtual environment. The second storyworld investigation engages existing archival maps, and 3-D wireframe models of the spaces to complete the radical indeterminacies and blank spaces inherent in the landscapes and townscapes of any literary narrative [6, p.97-100]. They are also used to influence the scale, spatial parameters and the development of blueprints for the VR storyworld.

My research investigates the suitability of the narrative perspective(s) within the texts for VR and suggests alternative perspectives to heighten immersion and create stronger self-referential ties within the digital narrative. The ethical implications of each proposed VR perspective and potential emotional responses will be discussed. Lastly, the difference in adapting short stories versus novels will be explored to discuss structural differences, ergonomic concerns and the adaptation of connotative narrative elements.

2.1 Theoretical Influences

A narratological approach to VR is being used throughout this research by engaging the subfields of VR narratology [7,8 & 9], transmedial narratology [10] and cognitive narratology [11] to create the methodology through the areas of inquiry. For the textual analysis of focalization, Genette’s stance on focalization will be used [12, p.188-9]. For the VR adaptations, Bucher’s six perspective for VR storytelling [9, p.96-7] and Pouillon’s notions of vision avec, vision par derrière and vision du dehors [13,

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p.173] will be used due to its medium-specific visual orientation. Martinez's "Theory of Storyworld Possible Selves" influences the adaptation of both storyworlds and focalization. Martinez posits that there are 4 storyworld possible selves (the feared self, the desired self, the self-schema & the past-possible self) and that first and third person perspectives develop the strongest self-referential activities [14].

2.2 Method

The overall research methodology is structured using a convergent mixed-methods paradigm [15, p.123] enabling the simultaneous collection of primary and secondary data sources to provide a holistic overview of the research problem. The primary data consists of the selected texts, interviews, and a questionnaire. The questionnaire consists of both open-ended and close-ended questions. It aims to examine users' experiences when immersed in a narrative represented in three formats: written text, film, and VR. This accommodates a technological ethnographic dimension within the data collection instrument which accounts for users' experiences within multiple realities [16, p.37]. The sample population, N= 120 participants while the sample size is, n=30. The participants were chosen based on stratified sampling where the criteria were age and literacy to produce 4 sample groups of different ages: n₁= 19-25, n₂= 26-35, n₃= 36-45 and n₄= 46-55. Published journal articles, texts and other audio-visual data are being used for secondary research.

3 RESEARCH PROGRESS

At present, I have completed 107 of the 120 questionnaires, the introduction and one body chapter of my dissertation. Two chapters are currently in-progress. I have conducted 4 interviews with an author, VR practitioner, computer engineer & legal expert.

4 CONCLUSION

As I move forward with my research, within a region where VR is yet to become a mainstream medium, and the absence of Caribbean based VR content is quite pronounced, there are several questions I would like to discuss during IEEE VR Doctoral Consortium (DC):

(1) Should the novels within my research be replaced entirely by short stories in favor of the comfort of the user or will an episodic structure work just as efficiently for VR storytelling?

(2) From your experience working with VR, will the incorporation of multiple sensory stimuli (sight, aural, olfactory and haptic) serve as a distraction from the narrative progression and result in the user engaging in reality-testing activities instead of following a particular pathway?

(3) Does the current structure of my research as a digital humanities project overlook or oversimplify the capabilities of VR and the computational input required in its creation, and if yes, what are some of these areas and how can they be improved?

By consulting with VR practitioners at the Doctoral Consortium, I am thoroughly convinced that my research can reach its conclusion and assist in catalyzing the use of VR within the Caribbean region.

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